The expression of pronominal subjects in Kuujärvi Ludic

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Kuujärvi Ludic is the southernmost dialect of the Ludic language (< Finnic < Uralic) spoken in the Kuujärvi (Rus. *Mikhailovskoe*) village, Olonets district, Republic of Karelia. It is markedly distinct from the more northern Ludic varieties on account of its extensive contact with closely related Veps (Rodionova, Nagurnaya 2018) and currently understudied, while being spoken by less than 70 people (Rodionova et al. 2017: 24).

In this paper we use the term 'pro-drop' not necessarily in the Generativist sense, but for practical purposes, i.e., to signify zero overt expression of the pronominal subject (cf. e.g. Pešková [2019]). Pro-drop is quite common in Finnic languages, as it is in Uralic in general (Janda et al. 2022: 894). Klumpp et al. (2018: 25-26) name it as the main strategy in both Karelian and Veps (the two languages most closely related to Ludic) as well as Finnish, Estonian and Livonian, while for Ingrian and Votic an overt pronominal subject strategy is claimed to be dominant. Upon closer inspection, some Finnic languages exhibit a split with 1st and 2nd person pronouns behaving one way and 3rd person ones being treated differently. In Finnish and Estonian pro-drop seems to mostly be relevant in discussion of the 1st and 2nd person (Duvallon, Chalvin 2004). In Ingrian, conversely, 3rd person pronouns used to be predominantly dropped in contrast to 1st and 2nd person ones, but in modern texts subject pronouns are predominantly expressed all across the personal system (Budennaya 2020).

Our study was carried out on a corpus of 681 clauses from 11 Kuujärvi Ludic texts collected from seven native speakers (5F, 2M, birth years 1948–1961) during our fieldwork in Kuujärvi in August 2024 and June 2026, as well as another RSUH expedition in June 2022, and one other text (VepKar Kujärven pruaznikad №3855, 2022). 313 of these clauses featured either an overt personal pronoun or zero as the subject.

Table 1 presents the distribution of such pronouns taking into account the tense in which they occur[1]. Neither in the 1st + 2nd person ($\chi^2 = 0.671$, $p = 0.413$), nor in the 3rd person ($\chi^2 = 1.292$, $p = 0.256$) the distribution over tense is statistically significant. This is in stark contrast with e.g. modern Ingrian data (Budennaya 2020: 41), where in the present the ratio of pronoun:zero in 1-2 person is 46:54 while in the past it is 19:8 ($\chi^2 = 5.053$, $p = 0.025$). This also lends legitimacy to the combined calculation of 1+2 vs. 3 person pronouns across tenses, which shows that the relative balance in 1st and 2nd person pronouns' being expressed or dropped (58:76) is significantly different from the dominant (32:147) pro-drop strategy in the 3rd person ($\chi^2 = 24.146$, $p < 0.001$).

Person		1+2			3		
Subject type		Pronoun	Zero	Total	Pronoun	Zero	Total
Tense	NonPST	16	26	42	6	42	48
	PST	42	50	92	26	105	131

Table 1. The expression of Kuujärvi Ludic pronouns.

[1] The values were also calculated separately for singular and plural pronouns but no significant difference was displayed with the greatest difference being 33:31 (SG) vs. 9:17 (PL) pronoun:zero distribution in 1-person PST contexts ($\chi^2 = 2.133$, $p = 0.144$) and 23:77 (SG) vs. 3:28 (PL) pronoun:zero distribution in 3-person PST contexts ($\chi^2 = 2.640$, $p = 0.104$).

Therefore, Kuujärvi Ludic displays an asymmetry in its pronominal subject coding: for 3rd person pronouns pro-drop is clearly preferential, while for 1st and 2nd person no clear preference is exhibited. This makes Kuujärvi Ludic a standout not only among the Uralic languages, but also among the languages of the world, as out of 711 languages in Dryer's (2011) sample only 32 exhibit a mixed pro-drop strategy, of which two are European — Irish and Finnish — but the asymmetry in Finnish is of a different nature with 1st and 2nd person pronouns clearly dropped, as discussed above, and 3rd person ones being mostly obligatory. What further complicates the picture for Finnish is its great divide between Standard Finnish and Colloquial Finnish. The latter demonstrates the opposite pattern as explicit subject pronouns accompany >80% of its 1st and 2nd-person verbs (Lappalainen 2004: 80-81 as cited in Duvallon, Chalvin 2004).

The seeming indifference to the PST/NonPST distinction in Ludic is, however, something that brings it closer to Russian, which also exhibits very similar numbers in the Past and non-Past tenses (13% and 14% zero marking respectively) despite Russian verbs already displaying the Subject's gender in the Past tense making the pronoun partially redundant (Grenoble 2001: 9). Ludic also complies with the principles of having zero pronouns after an overt pronoun in conjoined clauses (1) and in minimal clauses with a one-place predicate (2) as does Russian.

(1) *...a* ***müö*** *kaik* *keske-s.* *A* *huomese-l* *nouze-**m**...*
and **1PL** all middle-IN and morning-AD rise-**1PL**
'...and all of us in the middle. And in the morning we'd all get up…'

(2) ***Miä*** *ol-ii-n* *samyj* *hubaane.* *Däl'määne* *ol-ii-**n**.*
1SG be-PST-1SG most little last be-PST-**1SG**
'I was the smallest. The last one, I was.'

In addition, Ludic possesses another, more peculiar quality, which is its ability to introduce a new referent with no overt pronoun. This can happen both in situations of shifting from singular to plural — like in (3) where the shift implies the speaker getting married and coming back with his wife, which, however, is never mentioned in the text — and even in cases of a complete change of the topic (4).

(3) *Siga* *el-ii-**n*** ***miä*** *kodvaaže-n* *kuuz'* *vuo-t,*
DEM.DIST live-PST-**1SG** **1SG** a_little-ESS 6 year-PART
a *siid* *möst* *tänne* *tul-ii-**m***
and then again DEM.PROX.LAT come-PST-**1PL**
'I lived there a little, for six years, and then we came here again.'

(4) *Perti-d* *ol-dihe* *vilu-d.* *A* *magad-el-ii-**m*** *kaik* *lava-l.*
house-PL be-PST.3PL cold-PL and sleep-ITER-PST-**1PL** all floor-AD
'The houses were cold. And we all slept on the floor.'

In the presentation we will further examine the discourse, semantic and syntactic factors that influence the pro-drop strategy in Kuujärvi Ludic texts. We will also provide a comparative analysis of modern Kuujärvi texts with the texts recorded in 1983 to ascertain the possibility of Russian-language influence on the pro-drop system.

Glossing abbreviations

1, 3 – person; AD – adessive; PART – partitive; DEM – demonstrative; DIST – distal; ESS – essive; IN – inessive; ITER – iterative; LAT – lative; PL – plural; PROX – proximal; PST – past; SG – singular.

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